DSEH001 · DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION IN HR SYSTEMS

04

UNIT 4 READER

The Future of Work and HR Strategy

Gig work, hybrid work, workforce planning and leadership

Weeks 10 to 12 | Exam preparation | 9 readings explained

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About this reader

How to use it. This reader is a companion to the set readings, not a replacement for them. For each reading it explains the argument in plain language, lists the ideas you must hold, shows how to apply them, flags common confusions, and gives questions to think with as you prepare for the end-term examination. Read the original first, then use this reader to check your understanding. Folder names refer to the course Readings folder.

Unit 4 widens the lens from HR systems to the future of the workforce. The readings cover three linked shifts: the growth of gig and platform work, the spread of hybrid and flexible arrangements, and the reshaping of skills by automation and AI. Each shift moves costs and risks between employers, workers and the state, and Indian law is now responding, through the Code on Social Security 2020 and state laws such as Rajasthan's 2023 Act.

The unit ends where the course began, with leadership. Westerman and colleagues return to show what leaders of digital change actually do, and Scully-Russ and Torraco close their review with implications for HR development. Read this unit as preparation for synthesis: every reading should help you answer the question of what organizations owe their workers as work changes.

READING MAP

Week	Set readings	Folder	Exam-edition lectures
10	NITI Aayog (2022); Gratton (2021); Susskind (2020) selected chapter; Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020) whole article. Indian context: Code on Social Security 2020 ss. 113 to 114; Rajasthan Act 2023. Frameworks: WEF (2025)	Unit-1 Core, Unit-1 Supp., Unit-4 Core, Unit-4 Supp., Classroom	L1 to L3
11	Westerman et al. (2014) leadership and strategy chapters; Manuti and de Palma (2018) Ch 6; Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020) pp. 84 to 85, 88 to 89	Unit-1 Core, Unit-2 Core, Classroom	L1, L2
12	No new reading for L1 and L2; comprehensive review of the core readings for L3	All folders	L3

The readings, one by one

Week 10 **Core**

Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020). The changing nature and organization of work: An integrative review of the literature. *Human Resource Development Review*, 19(1), 66 to 93. Whole article.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Read the whole article now that you have met its parts. The review traces how technology, globalization and new organizational forms are changing what work is and how it is organized, including the rise of contingent and platform based work. It shows that these changes often transfer risk from organizations to individuals, who must manage their own careers, skills and security. The authors argue that HR development must respond at several levels: helping individuals adapt, redesigning work inside organizations, and contributing to wider policy debates about protection and opportunity.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Work is being reorganized, not only retooled, by technology.
- Contingent and platform work grow as organizations seek flexibility.
- Risk shifts from organizations to individual workers.
- HR development has individual, organizational and societal roles.

> **APPLY IT**
>
> Gig workers and automation-exposed role families are two faces of the same shift of risk from organizations to individuals.

> **QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**
>
> - Which workforce group in India bears the most risk from the changes this article describes, and why?

Week 10 **Report**

NITI Aayog. (2022). *India's Booming Gig and Platform Economy: Perspectives and Recommendations on the Future of Work*. Government of India.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

NITI Aayog's report is the main official estimate of India's gig workforce. It estimated about 7.7 million gig workers in 2020 to 21 and projected growth to about 23.5 million by 2029 to 30. It distinguishes platform workers, who find work through online platforms, from other gig workers, and it notes that much gig work sits in medium skilled roles. Its recommendations include extending social security to gig and platform workers, improving access to finance and skilling, and collecting better data on this workforce.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- About 7.7 million gig workers in 2020 to 21, projected to about 23.5 million by 2029 to 30.
- Platform workers are a subset of gig workers.
- Recommends social security, skilling, finance access and better data.

> **APPLY IT**
>
> Platform workers are legally distinct from employees and usually sit outside HR records. Ask which law, not which HR policy, protects them.

> **QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**
>
> - Why does the distinction between gig and platform workers matter for an employer's legal duties?

Week 10 **Indian context**

Government of India. (2020). *The Code on Social Security*, 2020, Sections 113 and 114. Official India Code text as amended to 21 November 2025.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The Code on Social Security brings gig workers and platform workers into India's social security law for the first time. Section 113 provides for their registration. Section 114 allows the government to frame schemes for them, covering areas such as life and disability cover, accident insurance, health and maternity benefits and old age protection, and provides for aggregators to contribute, at a rate of one to two percent of annual turnover, capped at five percent of the amount paid or payable to gig and platform workers. The Code was notified on 21 November 2025. Draft rules published in December 2025 propose eligibility after 90 days of work with one aggregator, or 120 days across several.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Gig and platform workers are recognized in social security law.
- Section 113: registration. Section 114: schemes and aggregator contributions.

- Aggregator contribution: 1 to 2 percent of turnover, capped at 5 percent of payouts to workers.
- Draft rules (December 2025) propose 90 day and 120 day eligibility thresholds.

APPLY IT

Judge coverage by computing enrolment across the full population of each worker tier, and state what you would need to know to judge eligibility.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Under the Code, this is a legal obligation for covered aggregators, not voluntary welfare.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- If only a small share of a tier is enrolled, what are three possible explanations, and what data would separate them?

Week 10 | Indian context

Government of Rajasthan. (2023). *The Rajasthan Platform Based Gig Workers (Registration and Welfare) Act, 2023.*

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Rajasthan's Act was the first state law dedicated to platform based gig workers. It sets up a welfare board with five representatives each of workers and aggregators, a registration system that gives each worker a unique identity regardless of how long they have worked on a platform, and a welfare fund supported by a fee levied on the value of each transaction aggregators handle. It also gives workers a route to raise grievances and a voice in the board's work. Comparing it with the central Code shows two models of protection: a national scheme framework and a state level board funded transaction by transaction.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- A state welfare board with worker representation.
- Registration with a unique identity for each worker.
- A welfare fund financed by a fee on aggregator transactions.
- A grievance route for workers.

APPLY IT

Compare the two laws: which offers platform workers more voice, and which offers more predictable funding?

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- List two ways the Rajasthan Act goes further than Sections 113 and 114, and one way it is narrower.

Week 10 **Framework**

World Economic Forum. (2025). *The Future of Jobs Report 2025*.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The WEF report surveys large employers about expected changes to 2030. It projects that about 170 million jobs will be created and about 92 million displaced, a net gain of about 78 million worldwide. Employers expect around 39 percent of workers' core skills to change by 2030, and they name five macro trends as the main drivers: technological change (especially AI and digital access), the green transition, economic pressures, demographic shifts and geoeconomic fragmentation. Fast growing skills include AI and big data, technology literacy, and human skills such as resilience, flexibility and curiosity.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Net global job growth to 2030, but large displacement inside that total.
- Roughly two fifths of core skills expected to change by 2030.
- Five drivers: technology, the green transition, economic pressure, demography and geoeconomic fragmentation.
- Both technical skills and human skills rise in value.

APPLY IT

Global averages describe a direction; an organization's own skill gaps and automation exposure decide its plan.

EASY TO CONFUSE

A net gain in jobs globally does not mean no worker is harmed. Skills based pivots can shift cost to the least protected unless transition plans are in place.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which Indian role families look most like WEF's declining roles? What transition plan would they need?

Week 10 **Licensed link**

Gratton, L. (2021). How to do hybrid right. *Harvard Business Review*, 99(3), May to June. Licensed link in Google Classroom.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Gratton argues that hybrid work should be designed around individual human concerns, not only institutional ones, and job by job rather than through one policy. She asks leaders to approach the design from four perspectives: jobs and tasks, employee preferences, projects and workflows, and inclusion and fairness. New arrangements are mapped along two axes: place (office or anywhere) and time (synchronous or asynchronous). Within the jobs and tasks perspective, she identifies four drivers of productivity to protect: energy, focus, coordination and cooperation.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Four perspectives: jobs and tasks, employee preferences, projects and workflows, inclusion and fairness.
- Two axes: place and time.
- Four productivity drivers: energy, focus, coordination, cooperation.
- Fairness between flexible and inflexible roles must be designed in.

APPLY IT

Most frontline roles cannot work remotely. Ask what flexibility in time, rather than place, could be offered.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Design one hybrid arrangement for a corporate role and one time-based flexibility for a frontline role.

Week 10 Supplementary

Susskind, D. (2020). *A World Without Work: Technology, Automation, and How We Should Respond.* Allen Lane. Selected chapter.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Susskind, an economist, asks whether technology will steadily reduce the demand for human work. He distinguishes two effects of automation: machines substitute for people in some tasks, but they also complement people and create new demand elsewhere. His argument is that, over the long run, the substituting force may grow stronger as machines take on more kinds of tasks, so that some people may find it hard to find well paid work even if jobs exist in total. He then asks what society and the state should do if that happens.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Automation both substitutes for and complements human work.
- The balance between the two can shift over time.
- Total job numbers can hide people who are left without good work.
- The policy question becomes how to share prosperity, not only how to retrain.

APPLY IT

A net gain in jobs globally does not settle what happens to a frontline worker whose role is automated.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Susskind's long run argument is a contested view, not a consensus forecast. Present it as one side of a debate, alongside WEF's employer survey.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which role families would Susskind worry about most, and what would an automation decision then owe them?

Week 11 Core

Westerman, G., Bonnet, D., & McAfee, A. (2014). *Leading Digital.* Leadership and strategy chapters.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The leadership chapters describe four capabilities that separate Digital Masters from the rest. They craft a transformative vision that is clear about how the business will change.

They engage the organization so that employees take part in shaping the change. They govern digital activity so that efforts are coordinated and resources are not wasted on duplicates. And they build strong ties between IT and business leaders so that technology serves strategy. The authors present these as learnable management practices rather than personal traits.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Vision: a concrete picture of how the business will work differently.
- Engagement: employees involved in shaping, not only receiving, change.
- Governance: coordinated priorities and shared resources.
- IT and business leaders working as partners.

> **APPLY IT**
>
> The four leadership capabilities are a checklist for any HR transformation strategy. Ask which one an organization lacks most.

> **QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**
>
> - Which of the four capabilities would have prevented duplicated HR systems bought by different departments?

Week 11 **Core**

Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020). Pages 84 to 85 and 88 to 89.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

These pages ask HR development to look beyond its role as the employer's functional agent. The authors call for HR to give workers a voice, to take part in how workplace technology is designed so that it augments people rather than only replacing them, and to take a broader, more activist role on the conditions of work, including for workers in insecure arrangements.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- HR is more than the employer's functional agent.
- Worker voice belongs in decisions about technology.
- HR can shape technology design toward augmenting people.
- A broader, activist role on conditions of work, including insecure work.

APPLY IT

Use these pages to justify the people side of an HR strategy: reskilling, transition support and worker protection are strategic choices, not charity.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which recommendation in an HR strategy augments workers, and which replaces them? Is the balance defensible?

The 6B framework (a course framework extending Lepak and Snell, 1999)

Response	What it means	When it fits
Build	Reskill existing staff internally	Skill gap closable within a realistic timeline
Buy	Hire the skills from outside	Skills scarce internally and needed fast
Borrow	Use contractors or partners	Short term or specialized need
Bridge	Move people into adjacent roles	Role declining but skills transferable
Bot	Automate, with a transition plan for affected staff	Automation risk above 0.70 and a redeployment path exists
Exit	Phase out through natural attrition	Role no longer needed and no viable bridge

WRITING A STRONG END-TERM ANSWER ON THE FUTURE OF WORK

One thesis. State your argument in a sentence at the start: what the organization should do, and why now.

Evidence for every claim. Support each major claim with a theory or a verified figure (for example, NITI Aayog's estimates or WEF 2025), and say where it comes from.

Algorithmic management. For platform workers, a defensible position combines transparency about how allocation works, human review of anomalies, and a working grievance pathway. Explainability alone is not enough.

Who bears the cost. For every recommendation, name who gains, who pays, and what protects the least protected group. This is where the WEF and Deloitte readings, Indian law and the course's ethics come together.

Key terms

Aggregator	A digital intermediary that connects buyers of services with gig or platform workers.
Gig worker	A person who works outside a traditional employer and employee relationship.
Platform worker	A gig worker who finds work through an online platform.
Reskilling	Training people for a different role, as distinct from upskilling in the same role.
Synchronous work	Work done at the same time as others, such as meetings or shifts.

References

Government of India. (2020). *The Code on Social Security, 2020*.

Government of Rajasthan. (2023). *The Rajasthan Platform Based Gig Workers (Registration and Welfare) Act, 2023*.

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NITI Aayog. (2022). *India's booming gig and platform economy*. Government of India.

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Figures from Deloitte or other consultancies should be quoted only when you can point to the page in the original report.